They were involved in many critical operations in certain countries in Africa and the Caribbean, namely, Côte d'Ivoire, Haiti, Burundi and Sudan. Kiran explains the significance of their role:

> One repeated lesson in governance is that there can be no guaranteed development without internal security. Well-trained and well-equipped professional police service is the best safeguard of human rights and democracy. Countries mentioned above and many more where the United Nations went were those whose police systems stood completely destroyed. Hence, civilian police component in the integrated mission was to rebuild police structures, recruit, appoint, mentor and train the locals to undo what was repugnant, and, most of all, to correct it themselves. I have seen the remarkable difference peace-keeping efforts have made, and continue to make, to the war-torn countries or areas from day one of the well-planned and well-resourced UN presence. No doubt, it takes time, but with concerted and well-resourced thought and through sustained strategies, countries do get back on their feet. The biggest beneficiaries undoubtedly are the weak, poor and vulnerable.

As to the stage when the UN departments ought to come together to send such peace-keeping missions and to which place, and also coordinate their activities, Kiran felt that such a decision was in the realm of the political leaders and diplomats. However, as soon as the Department of Peace-keeping Operations (DPO) senses a hot spot, it does initiate an academic interest so as not to be taken by surprise by the Security Council in case the latter focuses on that area.

About the role of women in international peace-keeping operations and how the DPO planned to correct their low representation, Kiran commented:

> We get women police officers in peace keeping only if the member-states forward their names. And usually they do not, even where they have good numbers, the reasons being their own country's needs, women being low on priority compared with men and [also due to] general indifference. Many countries still have mere symbolic presence of women in police work. Hence, they themselves are in need of correction. But we from the UN are pursuing forcefully the compelling need to increase the presence of qualified women candidates. And the UN has shown the way. Wherever we played a role in recruitment, we made the difference. Timor Leste is an example. More than 25 per cent of its newly created (by the UN as a peace-keeping mission) and trained police personnel are women. All peace keeping directly benefits women, for they are found the most victimized by the internal civil wars, and need women in uniform to provide the necessary and visible role which comes so naturally to them – equally to inspire the younger generation to take up the responsibility of nation building.

Regarding her plans upon returning home and whether she would be involved with the United Nations in any capacity, Kiran says:

> I have more than four years [in] the Indian Police Service to serve. I would dedicate myself to raising the quality of service along with addressing the neglected issues of personnel welfare, training and resources. The United Nations now will be in my subconscious. But it too will benefit in its own way – visibly or otherwise. I will remain grateful to the UN for all that it has taught me – most of all how privileged we are, as Indians, compared to all the deprivation and devastation I personally saw in the various missions where the United Nations serves.